

Brandon Gottshall

Blazin' Brigade Section Leader Candidate • Low Brass • Marine Corps Veteran
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Blazin' Brigade Leadership Selection Committee

July 14, 2026

VALDOSTA STATE UNIVERSITY
VALDOSTA, GA

Application for Blazin' Brigade Section Leader – Low Brass

Re: Blazin' Brigade Section Leader Application

Dear Selection Committee,

Leading from the front defines my approach to leadership. I am applying for the Section Leader position with the Blazin' Brigade because this role aligns with my strengths: **disciplined leadership, musical excellence, and building strong, cohesive teams**. As a Marine Corps veteran, Accredited Technology Instructor, and former low brass section leader, I know that clear expectations and shared accountability are the foundation of any successful ensemble.

My leadership toolkit was shaped by my service in the Marine Corps, where I held the roles of Quality Control NCO and Assistant Maintenance Chief. I managed millions in engineering equipment, wrote SOPs that reduced rework, and trained Marines in high-pressure environments. Those experiences taught me how to keep people composed, focused, and confident—qualities that matter most when an ensemble faces tough rehearsals, complex drill, and tight deadlines. In both settings, clear communication, efficient time management, and decisive action are essential for success. I recognize that music majors are usually chosen for these roles—and for good reason, as their expertise is invaluable. In addition to that musical depth, my contribution is to bring **structure, clarity, and professionalism** from operational leadership. Combined with the ensemble's musicianship, this approach strengthens rehearsal efficiency and elevates performance. Adaptability, teamwork, and steady communication are just as crucial in a collegiate ensemble as they are in military settings.

Mentorship drives me. As an Accredited Technology Instructor, I developed project-based curricula that turned beginners into confident practitioners by focusing on **process over perfection**. I enjoy helping students solve problems—not for them, but with them—because independence builds pride, and pride produces strong performers. As a section leader, I aim to create an environment where every member feels supported and motivated to grow, both personally and musically. I believe in approachable excellence—high standards delivered with patience, clarity, and respect.

After several years focused on service and career, I have rebuilt my musicianship intensively since August of this year. Working with the Worth County High School director, I developed a **daily practice system** focused on **technical fundamentals, air-flow, tone, and endurance**. The rapid progress I achieved through this routine deepened my empathy for new or struggling players. It reinforced my belief that progress is a system, not a personality trait—something any member can achieve with the right guidance and accountability.

My vision for leadership is to strengthen the **internal support structure of the section**. Rather than formal programs for their own sake, I care about building a culture where experienced players naturally mentor newer ones—checking in, offering honest but supportive feedback, and helping them find solutions when they get stuck. I want to model that behavior and encourage it across the section so no one feels like they're figuring things out alone. By applying Marine Corps principles—**leading by example, positive reinforcement, and building unit cohesion**—I'll help cultivate a motivated, confident, and

unified low brass section.

Thank you for considering my application. I am eager to collaborate with the leadership team and staff to support the ensemble's goals. I would be honored to serve on the 2025–2026 Leadership Team, and I am ready to contribute my **commitment, energy, and experience** to the excellence and momentum of the Blazin' Brigade.

Sincerely,

Brandon Gottshall